

A BlackBerry Playbook might not be the greatest tablet in town, with the limited number of apps available on AppWorld, but it turns out that the device can easily access the thousands and thousands of apps available on the Android Market.

While RIM did add the ability to run Android apps on the BlackBerry PlayBook with the 2.0 update, it still requires developers to manually upload their apps to the BlackBerry AppWorld, only after which users can install these apps. The extra steps required didn't enthrall developers much, and only a fraction of the apps on the Android Market have made it to the BlackBerry AppWorld.

What's better than that? Having the whole Android Market on your device, of course.

Strictly speaking, BlackBerry devices are very prickly when it comes to hacking. Extreme care is required, for instance, the Android Market installation process was something like this:

- ▶ On the PlayBook OS 2.0, install any Android app specially packaged for the PlayBook.
- ▶ Download CyanogenMod's Google Apps package, and copy a bunch of files from that package (which includes the Android Market) to a system folder on the PlayBook. The whole thing is done via an SCP client, which remotely logs in as root into the device.
- ▶ Launch the Android app installed in the first step, delete a few files, kill a few processes and run a particular script.
- ▶ One should then be able to launch the Android Market, after which app installs become a breeze.

Since the process involved messing around with system files, it wasn't too hard to alter the wrong files and have a broken OS, which could only be fixed via a restore.

There's another way to install Android apps on your PlayBook, but for that you need to have the .apk file as well as a few other tools installed on your PC. The .apk file needs to be repackaged into .bar, and also needs to be signed after which it can be side loaded into a PlayBook in developer mode. It's a fairly involved process, much more complicated than simply installing Android Market.

If the vast amount of Android apps weren't enough, a developer even found a way to run iOS apps on a PlayBook. The developer, who goes by the name of "Businesscat2000" on Crackberry.com Forums managed to provide the frameworks that iOS normally provided and got these apps running.